VOLUME FIVE

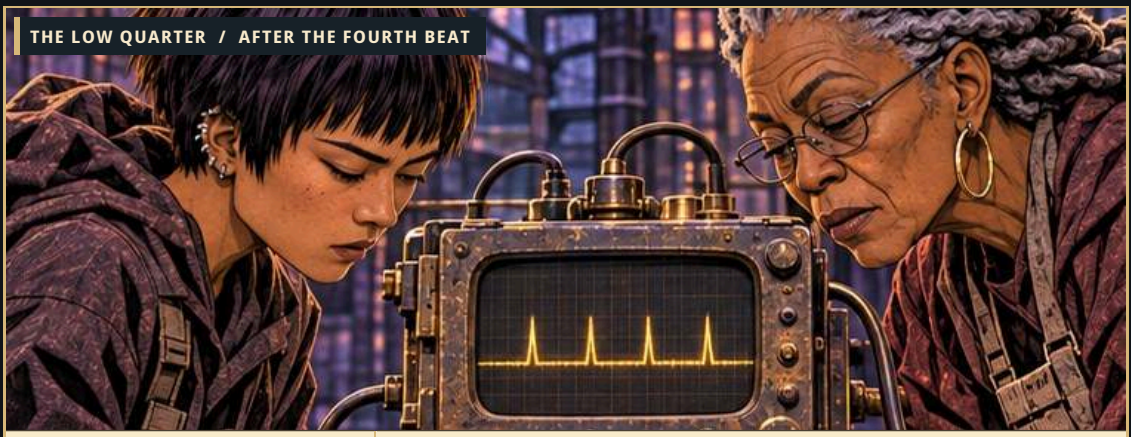
TECHOPS HERO

The House That Didn't Ask



STORY, WORLD & LYRICS

MIKE OLIVARES



MARA
The fourth one again.

IONA
Write down exactly what we heard. Not who we wanted it to be.



MARA
We could follow the stronger reading.

IONA
Last time I followed a reading. Not a person.



K / THOUGHT
Four beats. It used to mean somebody was about to play.



MIKE

We got voice. We got a clean end to the call. That counts.



K

The return path is still noisy.

MIKE

It can be noisy tomorrow.



K / THOUGHT

He talks about a fault like it can be allowed to exist.


Your bed. For now.
It has... cushions.
Luxury accommodations.
I'll try not to get attached.
Why does this feel like something I lost?


Kitchen's that way. Towels are in the hall closet.
I know how to fix things. I don't know why this room feels familiar.
I know her.
From the music?
Or from somewhere I can't reach.


I can find you a pillow.
Do I belong here?
Tonight, you belong on the couch.
A room can feel like home before you know why.
I don't know whose memory that is. I only know it hurts.


Coffee?
I don't know what I like.
We can start with the mug.
My hands remember what I can't.
Did you teach me this?
You already knew how.


Do you have a player?
Found one in a drawer.
A sound with no name. My chest knows where it goes.
You okay?
I think I miss it.
You don't have to explain.


It folds out.
Does it?
Usually.
A house can be strange and still be kind.


Three notes. A count-in.
You were keeping time.
I don't remember learning it.
You don't have to remember every step to take one.


I can tell you what I remember about this room. If you want.
tik tik
tok
My guitar hasn't come back in. He's already smiling.
How many times did you play it, Mike?


That was enough.
We'll leave it off.
I still don't know which memories are mine.
But tonight, I know where I am.



K
This needs a new strike plate.

MIKE
It needs a shoulder until Saturday.



K / THOUGHT
My hands remember exactly how. They never explain who taught them.



MIKE
Drink some water.

K
Is that a work order?

MIKE
It's a glass.



CLATTER

MIKE / OFF-PANEL

Top shelf. The cups moved months ago.

A FRAGMENT



K / THOUGHT

I knew which bills were overdue. Which drawers were too full.



K

I've been here before.

MIKE

No. I've been here before. You might be feeling the difference.



MIKE

This turns on the TV. This changes input. This turns it off when nothing else works.



K

It's an authentication problem.

MIKE

No. It's a television problem.



K / THOUGHT

I know that interval. I don't know where it lives.



IONA / FRAGMENT

You're late on three.

K / FRAGMENT

Then why do you always come in early?



ONE / TWO / THREE / —



K / THOUGHT

A gesture is not a date. A voice is not proof. I still miss it.



ON SCREEN

OBSERVED / REMEMBERED / SOURCE UNKNOWN

MIKE'S CABINET / THE COUNT-IN / MIDNIGHT CALLS



K

If I label it correctly, it might stop pretending to be a fact.



MIKE

The feed is off. What comes up afterward might still be old.

K

So the silence isn't clean.

MIKE

Neither are we.



K / THOUGHT

I drove because a voice said it needed me.



K / THOUGHT

Did she call me beautiful? Was the car even mine?



DELETED	SAVED AS
~~IONA~~	midnight_call_fragment / ORIGIN UNRESOLVED



MIKE
You found a person?

K
I found a feeling. It keeps borrowing the same face.



K
Did you ever drive across town because somebody needed a light fixed?



MIKE
Maybe. I've done a lot of favors. But that doesn't make it yours. Or hers.



MARA

We can tell him what this box did. Nothing more.



IONA

I'm on the receiver. No route change. Just voice.

K

Good.



K / RADIO

Do you remember why we counted in four?

IONA

I remember arguing about the fourth. I don't know which part you remember.



K / RADIO

There’s a song in my head. It’s angry at someone. It keeps wearing your face.



IONA

We hurt each other. I know that. But I won’t claim a memory I can’t verify.



K

I wanted you to tell me it was impossible.

IONA / RADIO

I can’t.

K

Then I’ll write what it feels like.



MIKE
That's a terrible studio.

K
It's a room.

MIKE
Then we're ahead of schedule.







I remember that buzz. I left it in.



MIKE
Want help with the levels?

K
Yes. Just the levels.



K / SINGING

She used to call at midnight, back when losing sleep felt youthful...



K / SINGING

I'd drive across the city just to hear her call me beautiful.



K / SINGING

She knew that I would always come; I knew how to be useful.



K / SINGING

Not because she loved me, but because I was useful.



K / THOUGHT

I need the line to be true. That is what frightens me.



K / SINGING

I gave her all my younger years so she could still feel youthful—



K / SINGING

The night I couldn't leave my bed, her week was suddenly too full...



K / SINGING

I kept my own grief folded; all her drawers were already too full.





K / SINGING

Then kissed the hands that fixed her world and told me they were beautiful.



K

My hands know how to make everything run. I can't ask them what happened.



MIKE

You can leave that verse. It's true that you felt it.

K

That's not the same thing.

MIKE

I know.



K / SINGING

If I had nothing left, would I still look beautiful?



K / SINGING

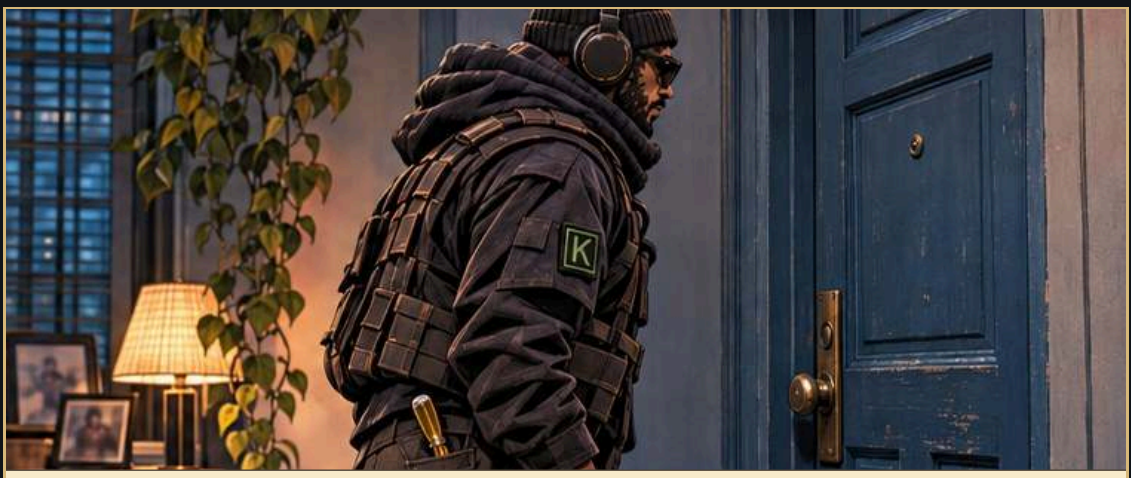
She watched the kettle reach a boil; the silence was so truthful.





K / SINGING

Then asked if I could fix the lock; there was still time to be useful.



K

The strike plate. It will take five minutes.



MIKE

I didn't ask.

K

You didn't have to.



TICK / CLICK



K
I can fix that.

MIKE
I know.



MIKE
Leave it. I'll deal with it tomorrow.

K
But it's broken.



MIKE

Yeah. Things break. Doesn't mean you have to fix them tonight.



K

Then why do you let me stay here?



MIKE

Because you're here.







MIKE

Sit down before I start charging you for standing.



K / SINGING

I finally said it without laughing; I finally sounded truthful.



K / SINGING

He thought somebody loved him every time they called him useful.



STOP

K

Don't upload it.

MIKE

Wasn't going to.

IN THE SONG



K / SINGING

For weeks, I watched her name light up and hoped for something beautiful—



K / SINGING

She called because the kitchen light went out, and I was useful.



K / THOUGHT

I am allowed not to answer a call that never came.



ON SCREEN

useful_rough_01.wav



ON SCREEN

ARTIST — K / MEMORY SOURCE — UNVERIFIED / REMOTE SYNC — OFF



MIKE

Breakfast’s usually whatever I don’t burn.

K

That narrows it down.

MIKE

You’re learning.

THE NEXT MORNING



K / THOUGHT

The room is still here. The person who offered it is still here.



K

The light's still out.

MIKE

We have a whole day to make poor decisions about lightbulbs.



K

Does breakfast count as a task?

MIKE

Only if you insist on doing the dishes.



ON SCREEN

PRIVATE / ROUGH TAKE / SOURCE UNRESOLVED



K / THOUGHT

I can keep a song without pretending it is evidence.



K / THOUGHT

Maybe a home is where something can stay broken until morning. And I can stay anyway.



MARA
You kept that backing track?

IONA
I kept the count-in.



ON SCREEN
INSTRUMENTAL STEM / LOCAL ARCHIVE / NO REMOTE SYNC



IONA
Same beat. Different words.

MARA
You want another take?

IONA
I want my own take.



IONA / SINGING

Under the weight of your beautiful lie,
Carrying memories, wondering why.



IONA / SINGING

Callously calling it “ride or die,”
Leaving me little but reasons to cry.



IONA

Don’t quantize my voice.

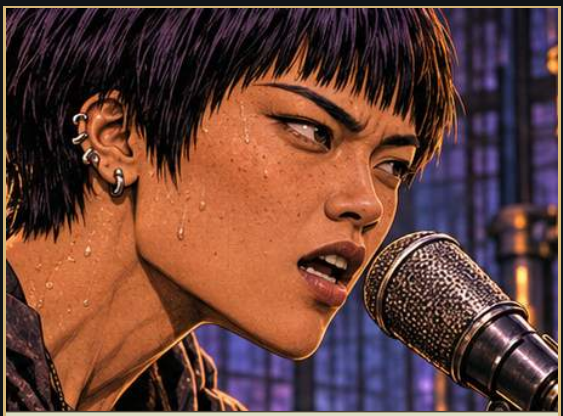
MARA

I wasn’t going to.



IONA / SINGING

You slept through the thunder; I watched the sky,
Learned how to whisper so you wouldn't hear me cry.



IONA / SINGING

I made myself useful; you kept me nearby,
Fixed every fracture and never asked why.



IONA / SINGING

Was I someone you loved or a place to hide?



IONA / SINGING

Ride or die, ride or die,
I wore out my heart keeping yours supplied.



IONA / SINGING

Now your key's on the counter; the morning is dry.



ON SCREEN

`ride_or_die_iona_take01.wav / INSTRUMENTAL: SAME STEM / VOCALS: IONA`



IONA / RADIO
Can I play you something?

K
You don't have to ask me to make it useful.



HISS / COUNT-IN / BEAT



K
That beat.

IONA / RADIO
I had an old copy.

K
So did I.



IONA / RADIO

I made myself useful; you kept me nearby…





K / RADIO

You found another way through it.

IONA

It needed a different flow.



IONA

Those lyrics are about what hurt. They aren't a verdict on everything we were.



K

I wrote something too. Not about facts I can prove. About the feeling.

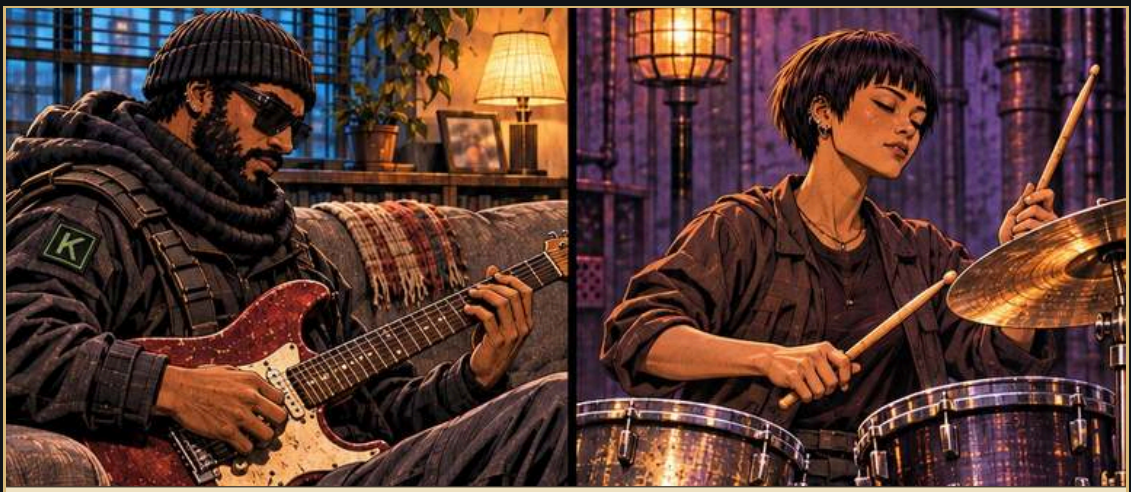


IONA

Keep it yours until you decide otherwise.

K / RADIO

You too.



The same music. Two voices. Two histories.



MIKE
Another repair request?

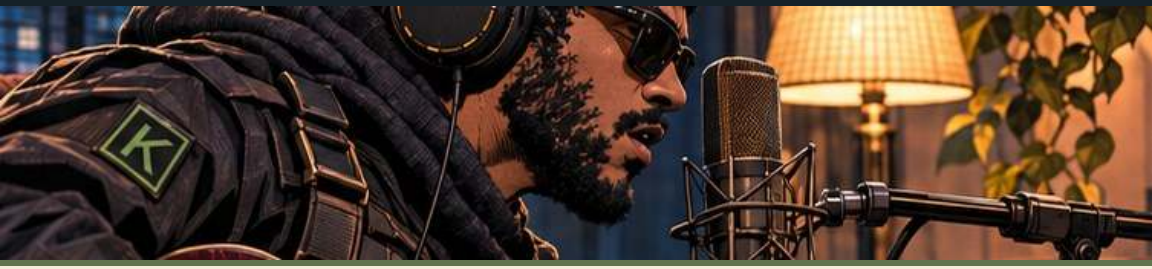
K
No. Just music.

MIKE
That's allowed here.



K / THOUGHT
I can listen without needing to solve what it means.

TWO SONGS. ONE HEARTBEAT.



PRIVATE ROUGH DEMO / K

Because I Was Useful

VERSE 1

She used to call at midnight, back when losing sleep felt youthful,
I'd drive across the city just to hear her call me beautiful.
I knew which bills were overdue, which kitchen drawers were too full,
She knew that I would always come; I knew how to be useful.
I told my friends she'd do the same; I wanted to sound truthful,
Then changed the subject when their smiles went quiet, small, and rueful.

CHORUS

Not because she loved me, but because I was useful,
She said that I was all she had; I needed that to be truthful.
I gave her all my younger years so she could still feel youthful—
Not because she loved me, but because I was useful.

VERSE 2

The night I couldn't leave my bed, her week was suddenly too full,
I said, "Of course, I understand," and almost sounded truthful.
I asked her what she loved in me; she listed what was useful,
Then kissed the hands that fixed her world and told me they were beautiful.
I kept my own grief folded; all her drawers were already too full,
And hated how I still felt hope whenever she looked rueful.



PRIVATE ROUGH DEMO / K

Because I Was Useful

CHORUS

Not because she loved me, but because I was useful,
She said that I was all she had; I needed that to be truthful.
I gave her all my younger years so she could still feel youthful—
Not because she loved me, but because I was useful.

BRIDGE

I asked, “If I had nothing left, would I still look beautiful?”
She watched the kettle reach a boil; the silence was so truthful.
She saw me lift my suitcase, looked inconvenienced, almost rueful,
Then asked if I could fix the lock; there was still time to be useful.

FINAL CHORUS

Not because she loved me, but because I was useful,
I finally said it without laughing; I finally sounded truthful.
I couldn’t buy those years back, couldn’t make that boy feel youthful—
He thought somebody loved him every time they called him useful.

OUTRO

I left her with the spare key; even leaving, I was useful,
She said she’d miss my hands; at least that part was truthful.
For weeks, I watched her name light up and hoped for something beautiful—
She called because the kitchen light went out, and I was useful.



LOCAL RECORDING / IONA

RIDE OR DIE

Under the weight of your beautiful lie,
Carrying memories, wondering why.
Reaching for someone who's passing me by,
Swallowing everything, trying to fly.

Callously calling it "ride or die,"
Leaving me little but reasons to cry.
Gathering pieces you scattered, I try—
Finally letting your promises die.

You called us forever; I called it ride or die,
Held onto your promise while the years went by.
You slept through the thunder; I watched the sky,
Learned how to whisper so you wouldn't hear me cry.



LOCAL RECORDING / IONA

RIDE OR DIE

I made myself useful; you kept me nearby,
Fixed every fracture and never asked why.
You kissed me goodnight with your bags standing by,
I stared at the ceiling rehearsing goodbye.

Was I someone you loved or a place to hide?
A hand on the wheel when you needed a ride?
I swallowed the questions; they burned me inside,
You called it devotion whenever I complied.

Ride or die, ride or die,
I wore out my heart keeping yours supplied.
You wanted forever with an exit nearby,
I wanted the truth, even dressed as a lie.

Now your key's on the counter; the morning is dry,
No rain on the window to help me deny.
I reach for the phone, then I set it aside—
For once, there is nobody here to satisfy.